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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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In Gaza, a fatal rush for aid in hot zones

U.S.-backed relief project routes crowds through militarized landscape

This article is by Louisa Loveluck, Gerry Shih, Miriam Berger, Imogen Piper, Jarrett Ley and Hazem Balousha

JERUSALEM — The repeated fatal shootings of Palestinians seeking food at distribution centers in Gaza since late May are an outcome of the aid project's flawed design, which drew enormous crowds and brought them in proximity to Israeli troops, who opened fire on multiple occasions, according to experts in humanitarian aid programs, witness testimony and visual evidence.

Shortly before the centers opened, the United Nations warned in a briefing paper that the model — developed by a group of former U.S. intelligence and defense officials and business executives working in close consultation with Israel — could lead to violence sparked by overcrowding. “Israeli forces or private military security companies may use force to control crowds,” the U.N. Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs said.

A Washington Post investigation found this occurred at least three times in just the first week of operations, with witnesses saying Israeli troops shot in the direction of crowds.

Since the American-backed Gaza Humanitarian Foundation (GHF) opened the first of four distribution centers in late May in areas controlled by the Israeli military, Palestinians have been shot in the vicinity of the sites nearly every day, killing more than 400 people and wounding thousands, according to the Office of the U.N. High Commissioner for Human Rights.

The Post found that this violence was in part the result of

SEE GAZA ON A12

Trump hosts Netanyahu amid hopes for ceasefire

BY MATT VISER, CLAIRE PARKER AND RACHEL CHASON

President Donald Trump hosted Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu at a dinner Monday night, with the two meeting at a key moment and lavishing praise on each other amid efforts to reach a ceasefire in Gaza and determine the course of negotiations with Iran.

“I want to express the appreciation and admiration not only of all Israelis, but of the Jewish people,” Netanyahu said. He then presented Trump with a letter he said he wrote nominating the president for the Nobel Peace Prize.

“You deserve it,” Netanyahu said as Trump read the letter, approvingly.

“Coming from you in particular, this is very meaningful,” Trump said.

In a notable shift, Trump also pledged to send more weapons to Ukraine to aid the country in its war against Russia, saying they would be aimed at helping their defensive capabilities.

SEE NETANYAHU ON A15



DESIREE RIOS/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Texas game warden officers search along the Guadalupe River on Monday in Texas, where flooding killed at least 27 children.

When children die, grief is exponential

BY DAVID OVALLE

The Central Texas flash flooding that killed at least 104 people is among the deadliest flood events in the past 50 years. But it's the disproportionate number of children who perished that sets it apart from others in recent history.

As of Monday, at least 27 children were among the dead, about a third of the total casualties, a number made more jarring in an era of modern forecasting and communication meant to prevent such disasters.

Angry river water, engorged

Loss of young lives turns tragedy of Tex. flooding into something worse

by historic levels of rain, attacked the most wholesome of American institutions: summer camps for kids. Unlike the “Children's Blizzard” believed to have killed hundreds of young people in the Midwest in 1888, or the Galveston, Texas, hurricane that collapsed an orphanage and claimed 90 kids in 1900, the

scenes of innocence lost unfolded almost immediately on social media and television for a global audience.

The 10 girls from venerable Camp Mystic who remained missing amid the threat of more floods. The father desperately searching for his 8-year-old among twisted trees and waterlogged stuffed animals near the banks of the Guadalupe River. Twin sisters killed are granddaughters of a former Miami Herald publisher — who founded and chairs an organization that advocates for early-childhood education.

The Texas tragedy comes as experts worry that children around the globe are increasingly at risk from extreme weather events because they are smaller physically, less developed psychologically and dependent on adults for support and protection. An estimated 710 million young people around the world, most in developing countries, are at particular risk because of climate change, the advocacy group Save The Children estimated in 2021.

In the United States, research on how natural disasters affect

SEE TEXAS ON A8

U.S. reports its highest number of measles cases since 1992

BY LENA H. SUN

The United States has reached its highest annual measles case tally in 33 years, hitting at least 1,277 confirmed cases across 38 states and the District of Columbia.

The milestone marks a public health reversal in defeating a highly contagious, vaccine-pre-

ventable disease as the anti-vaccine movement gains strength.

The nation surpassed infections reported in 2019, reaching the largest number of cases since 1992, when officials recorded more than 2,100 infections, according to data published Friday from the Johns Hopkins University Center for Outbreak Response Innovation (CORI).

“It's devastating,” said Claire Hannan, executive director of the Association of Immunization Managers, a national organization of state and local immunization officials. “We worked so hard to eliminate the threat of measles and to keep it at bay.”

Authorities said at least 155 people have been hospitalized and three people have died of

measles-related complications this year. The dead include two otherwise healthy children in Texas and a man in New Mexico, all of who were unvaccinated. In contrast, only three measles deaths were reported between 2001 and 2024, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.

About 92 percent of measles

cases in 2025 were in people who were either unvaccinated or whose vaccination status was unknown, according to the CDC.

Data from the CDC does not yet reflect the record as it is updated weekly on Wednesdays, while the

SEE MEASLES ON A6

Vaccines: What to know about measles booster shots. A7



MOSA'AB ELSHAMY/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Wheatfield with bros

The Tour de France peloton pedals by a field of wheat during the 110.8-mile third stage from Valenciennes to Dunkirk in northern France. The stage included a few crashes. **Story, B8**

Ben's Chili Bowl overhaul, with an eye on preservation

The famed D.C. half-smoke restaurant wants to ensure it retains links to its nostalgic past

BY TIM CARMAN

The air inside Ben's Chili Bowl sits heavy on the skin, like a weighted blanket. The weather outside is sweltering, hovering somewhere in the low 90s, but it has to be even hotter in the front room of the historic U Street diner. Six rows of juicy links huddle on a hot griddle near the front window, elevating one's hunger and body temperature at the same time. A single fan near the grill is fighting a losing battle against the heat.

The fan has become necessary because the HVAC system is working at half-capacity and two overburdened window-unit ACs struggle to make up the difference, says Vida Ali, one of several family members who run the business that's practically synon-

ymous with Washington's cultural and political history. Ali is walking a reporter through the aging building, originally conceived as the Minnehaha Nickelodeon Theater in 1910 and once an active pool hall before Ben and Virginia Ali converted it into the Bowl in 1958.

The Ali family has been considering renovations to the U Street NW location for at least a couple of years, as Washington's brutal summers have taken a toll not only on Ben's customers but also on a staff that works daily next to the sizzling flattops. This year, the Alis decided they can put it off no longer: At 11:59 p.m. on July 14, Virginia Ali, her sons and their wives will shut down the original location for several months to repair the roof, fix the HVAC system,

SEE BEN'S ON A9

IN THE NEWS

About-face at VA The Department of Veterans Affairs reversed course on large-scale layoffs, opting to reduce staff through retirements, attrition and other means. **A16**

More hearings A federal judge in Maryland ordered the Trump administration to detail its new plan to deport Kilmar Abrego García. **B13**

THE NATION
An active shooter was killed in an exchange of gunfire at a Border Patrol facility in Texas. **A6**
The Justice Department said no client list exists in the FBI's Jeffrey Epstein files. **A20**

THE WORLD
The Houthis said they sank a ship in the Red Sea, and Israel struck Yemeni ports. **A15**
Russia's transportation minister was found dead in his car hours after being fired. **A15**

STYLE
As some people use AI to help send messages on dating apps, others are left wondering what's real and what's fake. **B1**
After exploring art pop, country and rock, Kesha's first independent album, “Period,” is a return to the party. **B1**

THE REGION
An 80-year-old man allegedly killed his wife by attacking her with a hammer in Montgomery County. **B13**
Nearly 30 people, mostly juveniles, were arrested on fireworks-related charges in D.C. over the holiday weekend, police said. **B14**

SPORTS
D.C.'s bid for the 2031 Women's World Cup may be impacted if there are significant delays in the Commanders stadium deal. **B7**
The Nationals need more than a new general manager as they remake their front office, Barry Svrluga writes. **B7**

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